cannot be matched by the UPNO and NLD. In sum, arms are still relevant to party politics in a frontier where the state has withdrawn its monopoly on the use of violence. However, the PNO case shows that soft power could also come in handy.

The political order of the frontier is not fixed, but is constantly being constituted by the interactions of different actors. The PNLO was one of the signatories in the Nationwide Ceasefire Agreement in October 2015. The significance of this development is that the PNLO has been removed from the unlawful associations list and it can now enjoy full legal status and conduct formal business, or engage with INGOs to improve the living standards of Pa-O people. This development will inevitably undermine the PNO's authority, and even challenge its legitimacy to rule the Pa-O. While the PNLO has no immediate intention to form a political party, it does not rule out the possibility of working with the UPNO.[32] If the argument is valid that the SNDP's loss and the PNO's victory was partly because the latter had an army, would the alliance of the UPNO, a political party with a strong ethnic background, and the PNLO, a ceasefire armed group with teeth, be a game changer and serve as a platform to challenge the PNO? And if the alliance does materialize, what is the edge (soft power) that could tilt the balance to its favour? Or will the area return to conflict? It will be interesting to see what further changes occur in the southern Shan State in the coming years, and what changes to the region a parliament under the NLD will bring.

Notes

1 Interview, 28 August 2014 in Taunggyi.
2 Interview with a PNLO Central Committee member on 6 November 2015.
3 Interview with UPNO leader on 15 January 2015.
4 Interview with villagers near Kakku, where the PNO helped to repair the monastery, 7 November 2014. On the relationship between social welfare networks and politics in Myanmar more generally, see McCarthy, this volume.
5 There were even talks of a merger of the two parties, see "Biggest Shan Political Parties to Consider Merger" *The Irrawaddy*, 1 April 2014 <http://www.irrawaddy.org/burma/biggest-shan-political-parties-consider-merger.html>. Accessed 24 March 2015.
6 Union Election Commission, Announcement 92/2015 and 93/2015.
7 In 1993, SLORC formed the Union Solidarity and Development Association